

Swimming upriver

To breed, or spawn, salmon swim up the same river they once swam down as young fish. They jump rapids and avoid hungry bears. Those that survive the “salmon run” are exhausted by the effort.

Salmon

Sockeye salmon go through many changes in their lives. They move from one habitat to another—from freshwater to salty water, and then back to fresh. They switch from eating insects to plankton. And they change color—from clear to light green, through to silver, then blue, and finally red.

To the sea

The smolt mature into adult salmon once they reach the ocean. They spend up to four years at sea, feeding on tiny animals called zooplankton. Sockeye salmon are found at depths of 50–108 ft (15–33 m) in the Pacific Ocean.

See also

Find out about the octopus (70–71), who also dies after breeding.



Grizzly bear These fearsome bears love to feed on salmon. As the salmon swim upriver to spawn, the bears wade out into the rapids to fish for them.



Freshwater eel The journey, or migration, that salmon make to breed, from sea to river, is called anadromous. Freshwater eels follow the opposite pattern, swimming from river to sea. This migration is called catadromous.



Century plant Salmon reproduce just once in their lives. This behavior is also found in plants, such as the century plant, which flowers once and then dies.

